

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 178

By Gant

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Peebles Funeral Home.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly are pleased to recognize those long-standing businesses that have provided outstanding service to the citizens of their community; and

WHEREAS, one such business is the family-owned Peebles Funeral Home, which has stood as a pillar of respectful concern for those who have lost family, friends, and loved ones in West Tennessee since 1884; and

WHEREAS, Peebles Funeral Home takes pride in its roots, with a history stretching back to the first undertaker in Fayette County, Colonel Simon H. Walker, a cabinetmaker by trade who started making coffins in Somerville in 1826; and

WHEREAS, Colonel Walker was known as an honest businessman and served in the undertaking business with his stepson, Thomas E.A. Fraser; after Colonel Walker's death in 1862, Mr. Fraser inherited the undertaking business from his stepfather; and

WHEREAS, the funeral business experienced a big change in the 1850s, as small cabinetmaking and woodworking shops that employed carpenters and craftsmen to make wood coffins had to adjust to accommodate an alternative kind of coffin made by cast-iron stove manufacturers that made metallic cases for burials; and

WHEREAS, Thomas E.A. Fraser continued to manufacture wood coffins, as well as providing metallic coffins, as a sole proprietor until 1870, at which time he collaborated with another Fayette County undertaker, William W. Greenway, until 1872; and

WHEREAS, in 1878, at the age of fifty-nine, Stewart Freeman Woodruff became an undertaker; a decade later, his nephew D. Reddick Cleaves, a carpenter, purchased the

undertaking business in Mason, while Mr. Woodruff continued his undertaking business in Somerville; and

WHEREAS, after Mr. Woodruff's death in 1895, his daughter, Mary Woodruff Wetzler, inherited her father's undertaking business and its stock of coffins, materials, hearses, and horses; Mrs. Wetzler was married to John Wetzler, who had worked with and learned the undertaking business from his father-in-law; and

WHEREAS, John Wetzler, who had graduated from the Oriental School of Embalming in Boston, Massachusetts, in 1892, established the first funeral home in Fayette County; John and Mary Wetzler's son, John Howard Wetzler, graduated from the Gupton-Jones School of Embalming in Nashville on July 6, 1920, and continued operating the family business until the 1950s; and

WHEREAS, as Fayette County continued to grow, so did the funeral business; Henry F. Bryant owned and operated Bryant Funeral Home in Moscow from 1946 to 1949, while John Wilson Simmons, owner of Simmons Funeral Home, also operated in Moscow in 1947; and

WHEREAS, Harry Crawford began operating Crawford Funeral Home in Somerville in 1951 and was joined by Herbert Wright in 1959; and

WHEREAS, Crawford Funeral Home and Simmons Funeral Home directed until January 1972, at which time they were purchased by Thomas Gordon Peebles and consolidated into Fayette County Funeral Home in February 1973; and

WHEREAS, the present Peebles Fayette County Funeral Homes and Cremation Center - Main Chapel, located at 18020 Highway 64 in Somerville, was built in 1974; it was the first and only full-service funeral home facility built specifically for a funeral home in Fayette County, and it is still being utilized today; and

WHEREAS, in anticipation of changes in the funeral industry, the Peebles Cremation Center was built in 2003; the West Chapel, cremation center, and cemetery are all located on the same property; and

WHEREAS, on May 30, 2014, Michael and Jennifer Tilghman were blessed with an opportunity to purchase the funeral homes, cemetery, cremation center, and pet business; prior to purchasing the business, Michael Tilghman had worked with Mr. and Mrs. Peebles for a period of five years; and

WHEREAS, since 1884, Peebles Funeral Home has rendered sterling service to the good people of West Tennessee, and it is wholly fitting that we honor this exemplary Tennessee institution; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Peebles Funeral Home upon providing 141 years of service to its community and applaud the long-standing commitment to excellence and dedication exhibited by its owners and employees.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.